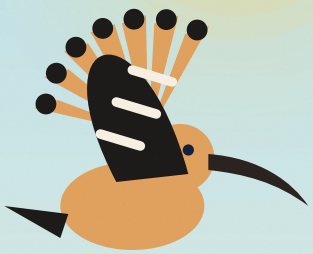
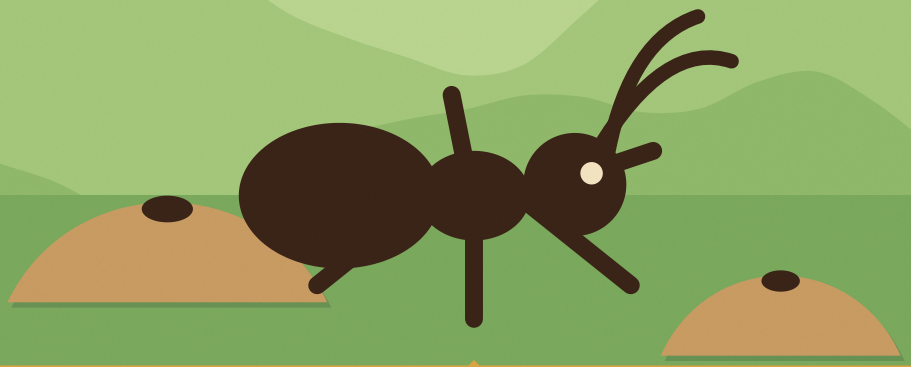
STORIES FROM THE QURAN · 5

Sulayman and the Ant

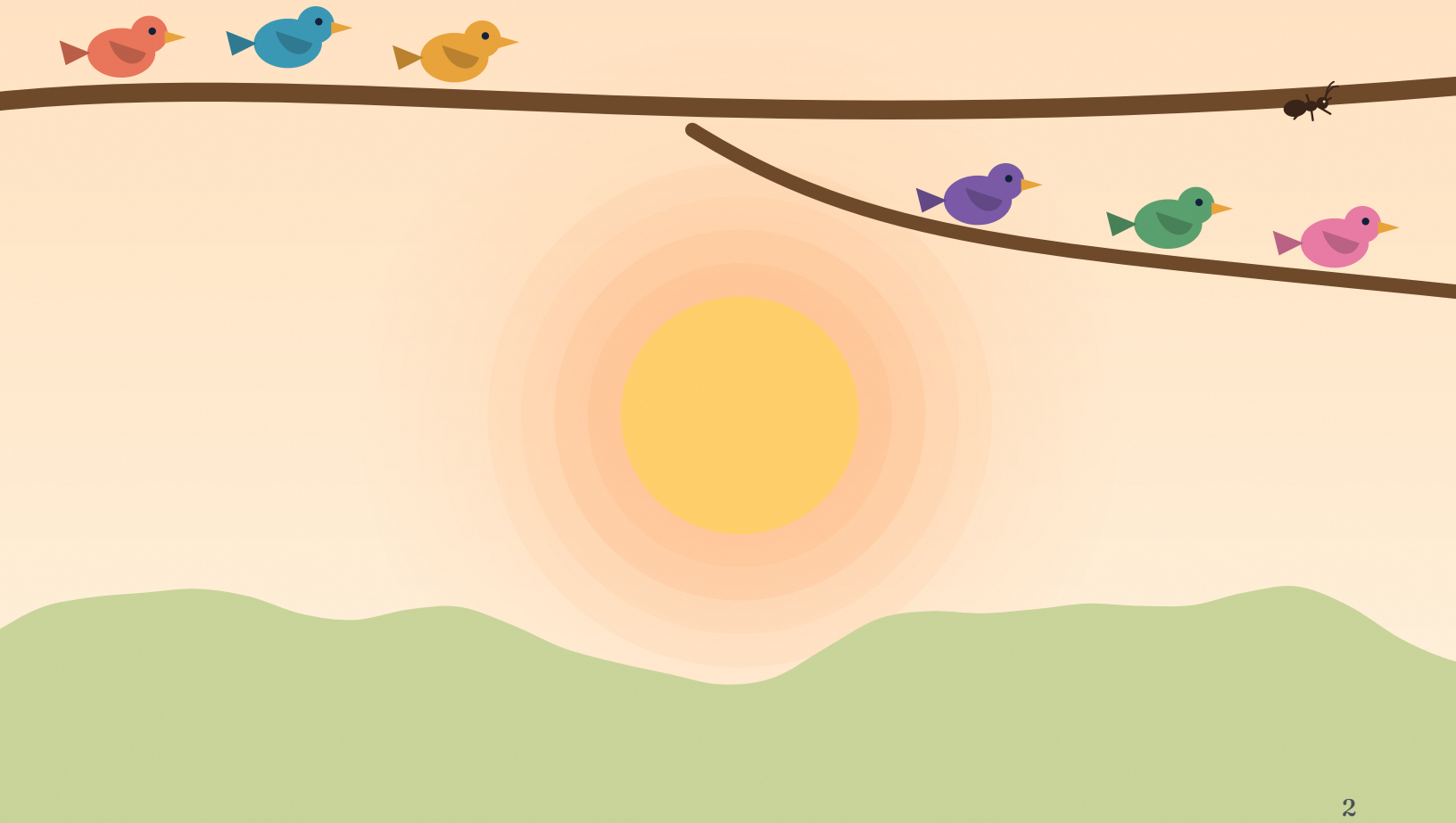
سليمان والنملة



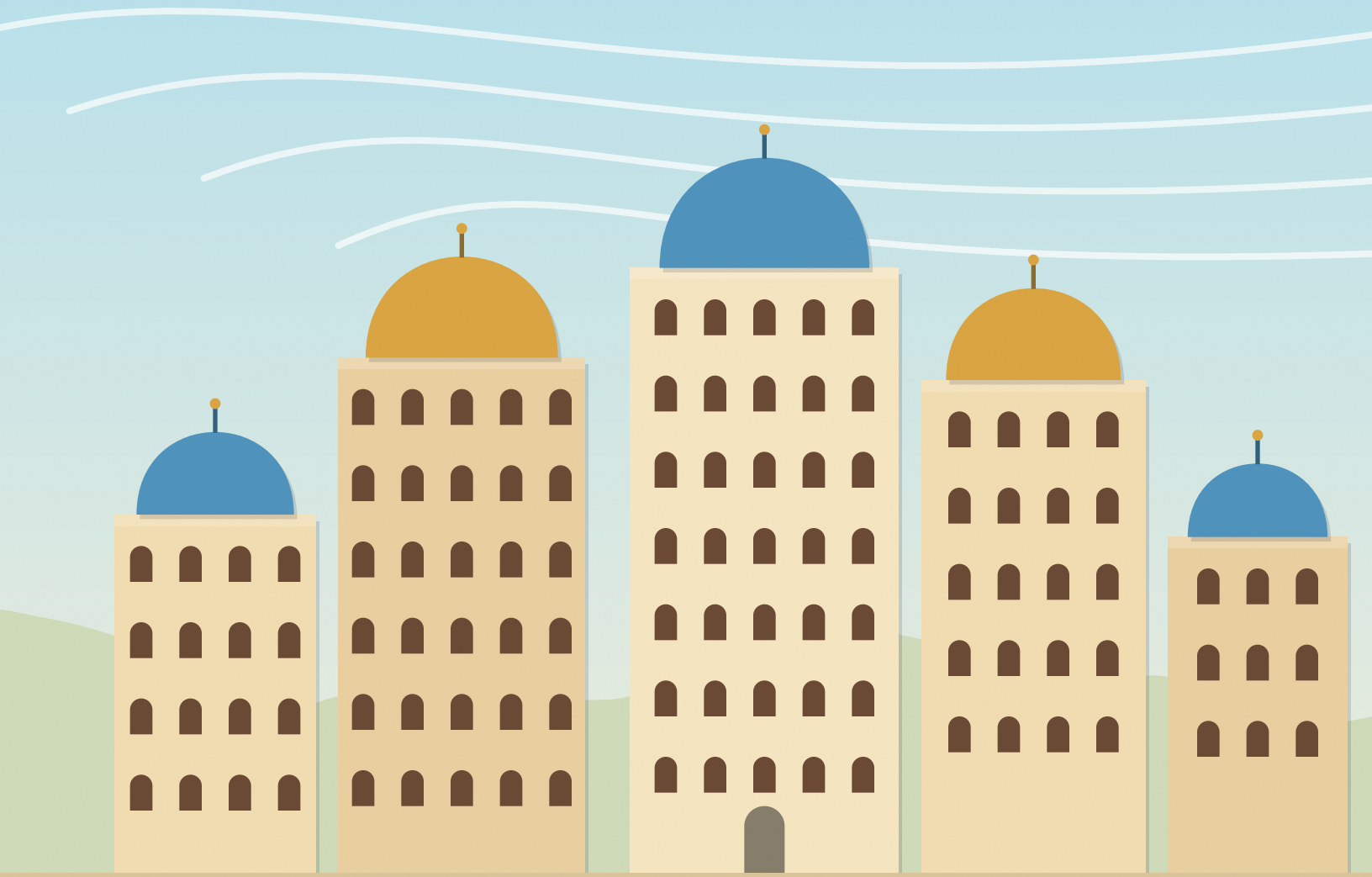


Long ago there lived a wise king and prophet named Dawud, and his son Sulayman (peace be upon him).

Allah gave them both knowledge. Sulayman said, “People, we have been taught the speech of the birds!”

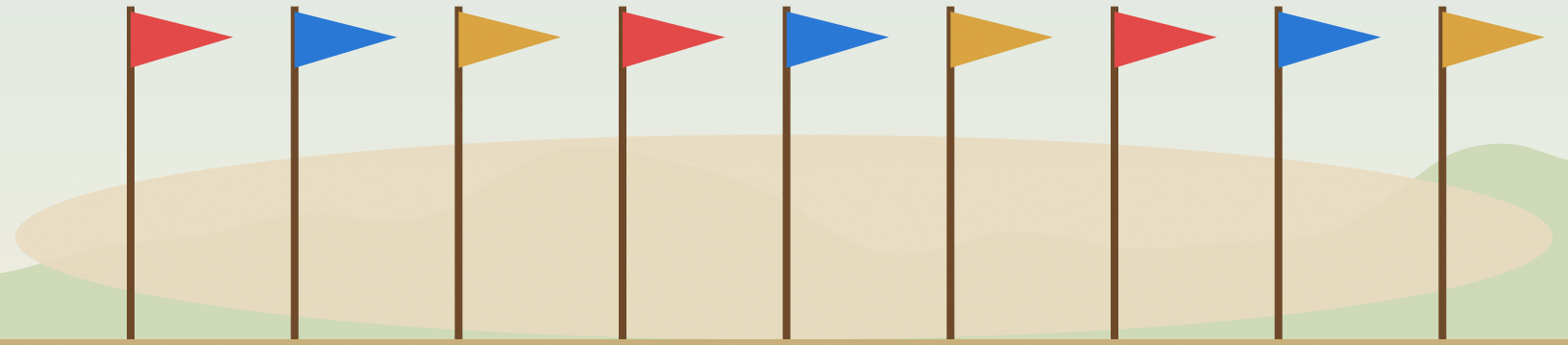


Allah gave Sulayman a great kingdom. The wind obeyed him, carrying him a month's journey in a morning. The jinn worked for him, building palaces, tall arches and great bowls as big as ponds.



One day Sulayman gathered his army: jinn, people and birds, all in long, neat rows.

Off they marched across the land.

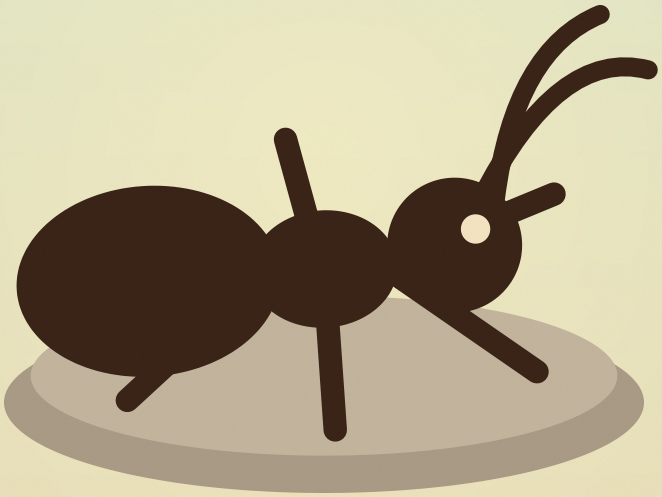


They came to a valley full of ants, thousands and thousands of them, busy carrying seeds and crumbs.



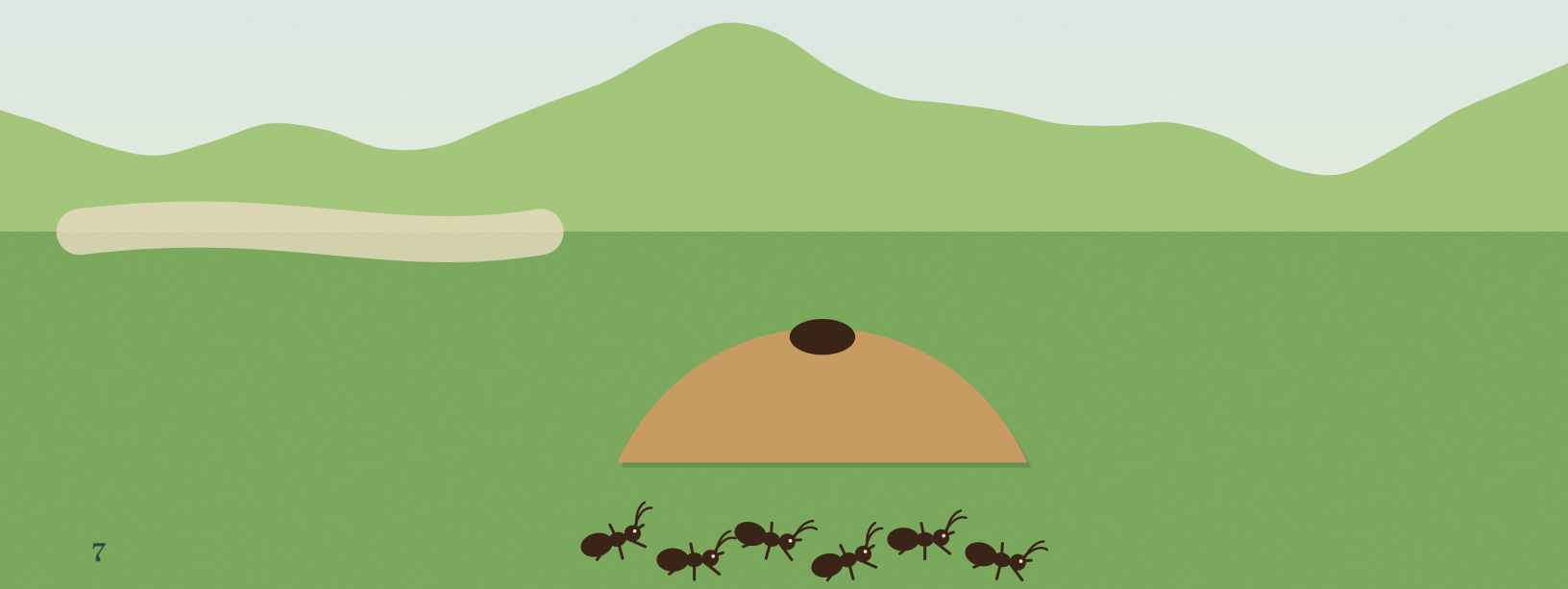
One ant saw the army coming and called out:

“O ants, go into your homes, so that Sulayman and his soldiers do not crush you without noticing!”



Sulayman heard the tiny ant. He smiled, and laughed at her words, and he stopped his whole army so the ants could get home safely.

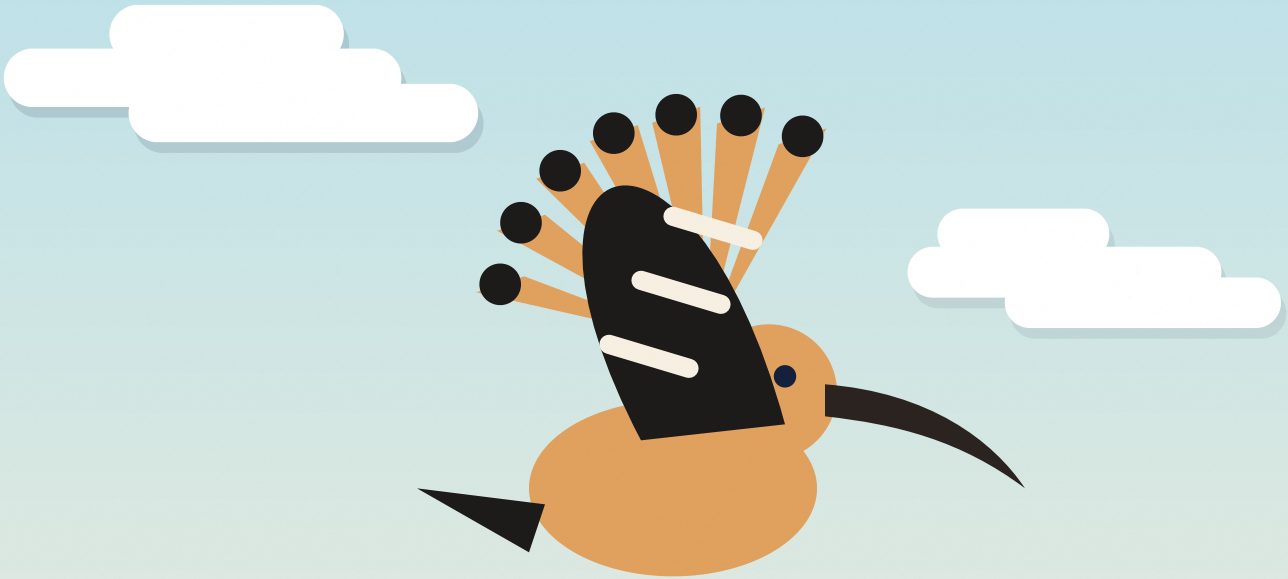
Then he prayed: “My Lord, help me to be grateful for all Your blessings.”



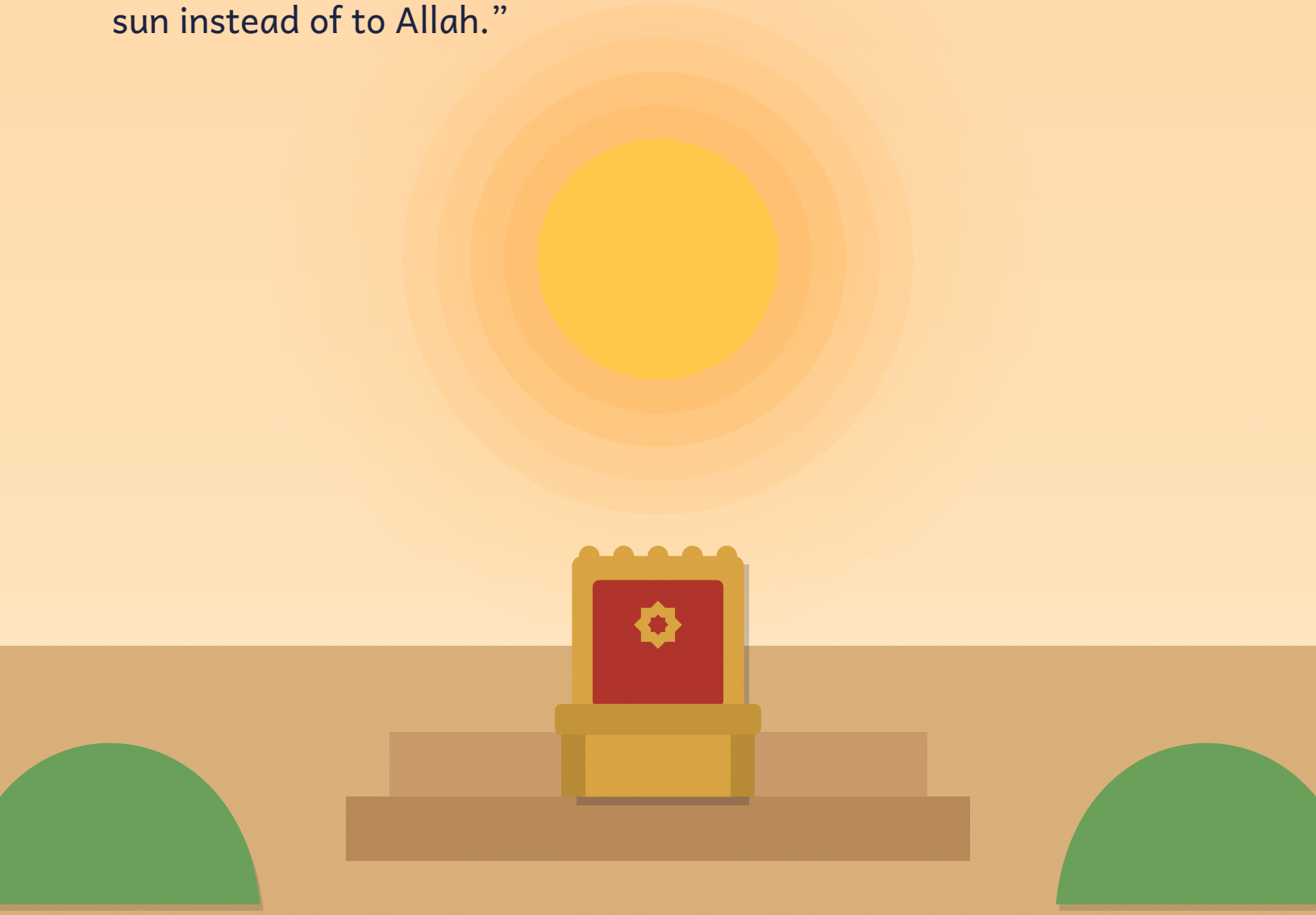
Later Sulayman looked over the birds. “Why do I not see the hoopoe?” he asked. “Is he missing? If he has no good reason, he will be in trouble!”



Soon the hoopoe came flying back. “I have news you do not know!” he said. “I have come from the land of Saba’ with news that is certain.”



“There is a queen ruling there, with everything she could wish for, and a magnificent throne. But she and her people bow down to the sun instead of to Allah.”



“We shall see if you are telling the truth,” said Sulayman. He wrote a letter and gave it to the hoopoe to carry.

It began: “In the name of Allah, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful.”



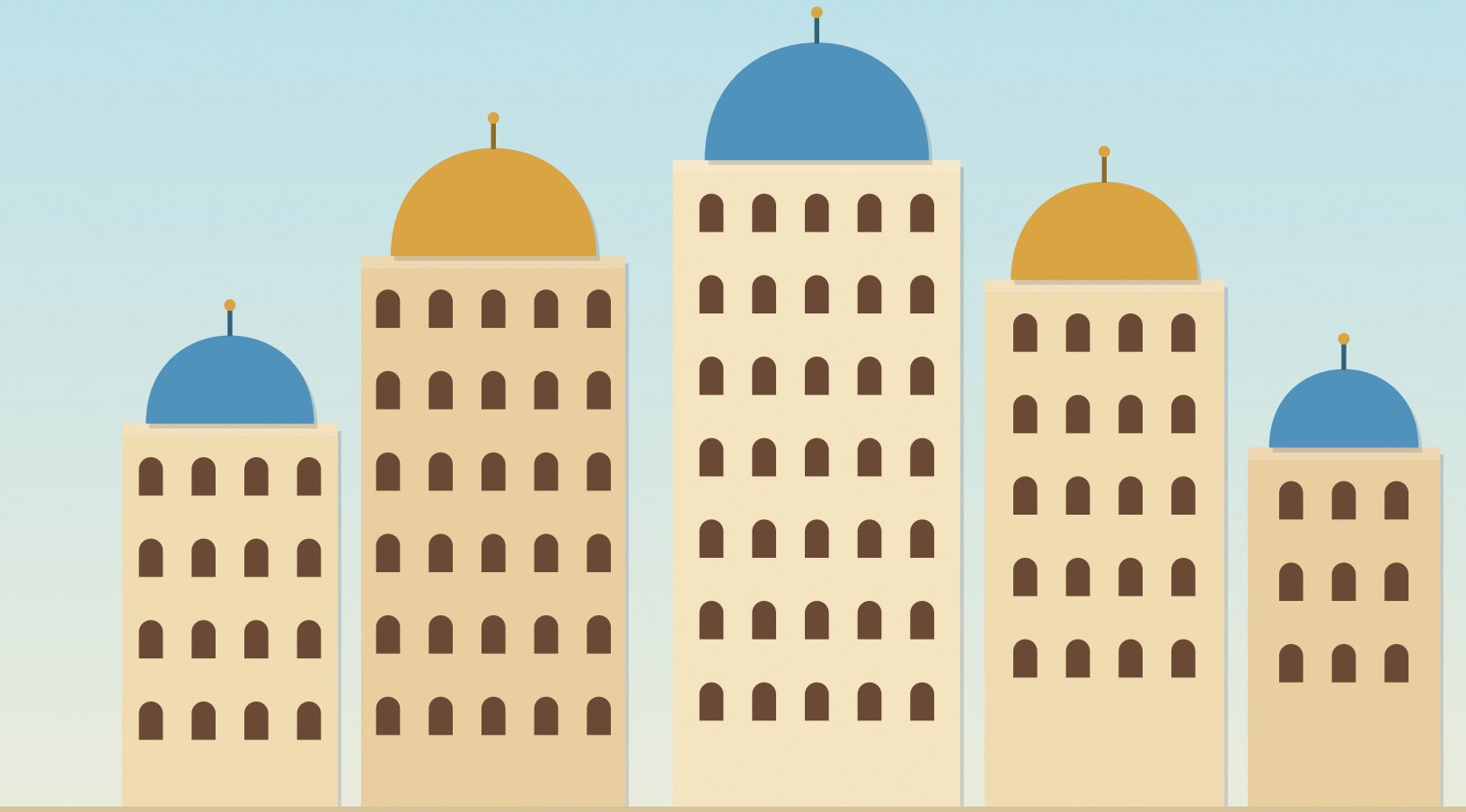




The queen read the letter and asked her chiefs what to do. Then she decided to send Sulayman a gift of treasure, to see what he would do.



But Sulayman said: “Are you giving me money? What Allah has given me is better than anything you could give.”

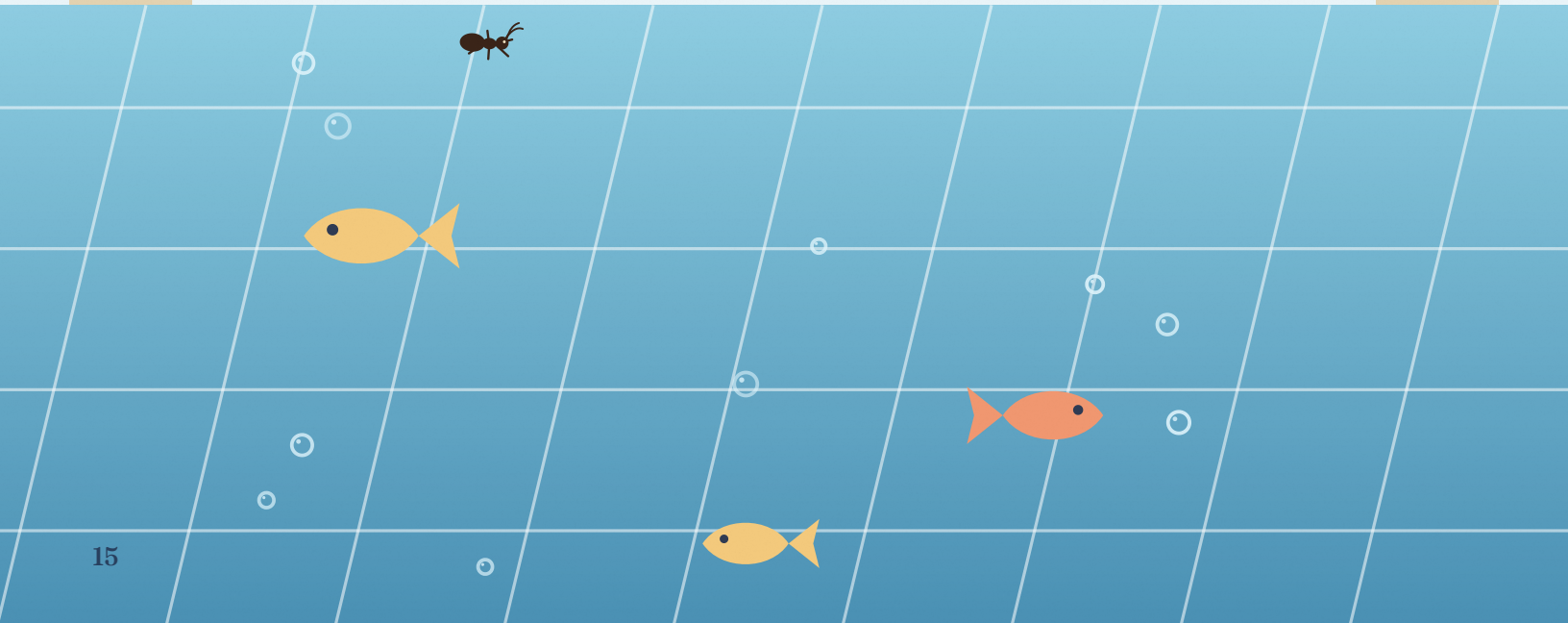


Before the queen arrived, Sulayman asked who could bring her throne to him. One who had knowledge from the Book brought it, in the blink of an eye!

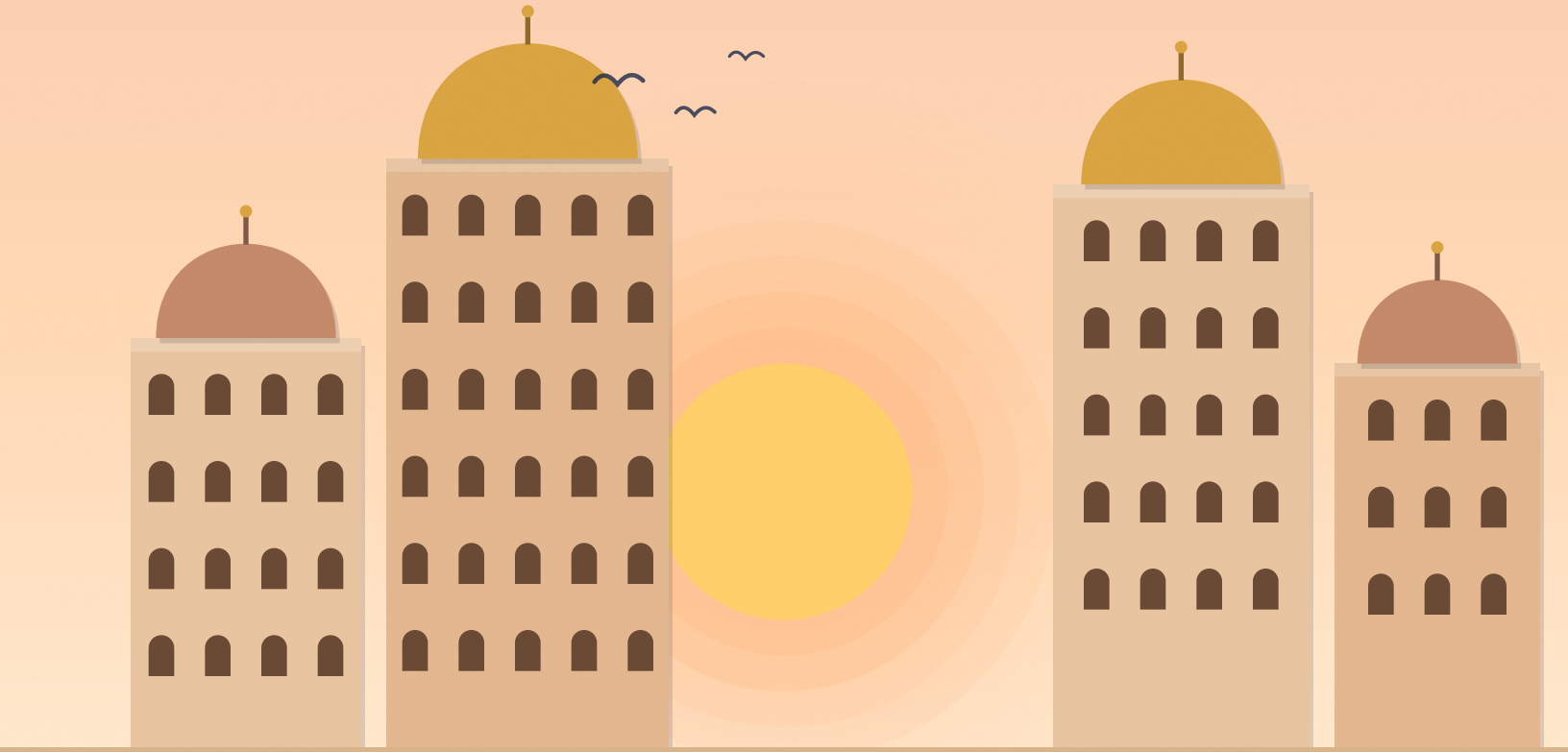
“This is from the kindness of my Lord,” said Sulayman, “to test whether I am grateful.”



When the queen came, she was asked to enter the palace. The floor looked like a pool of water, so she lifted her dress so it would not get wet. But it was smooth glass, with water underneath!

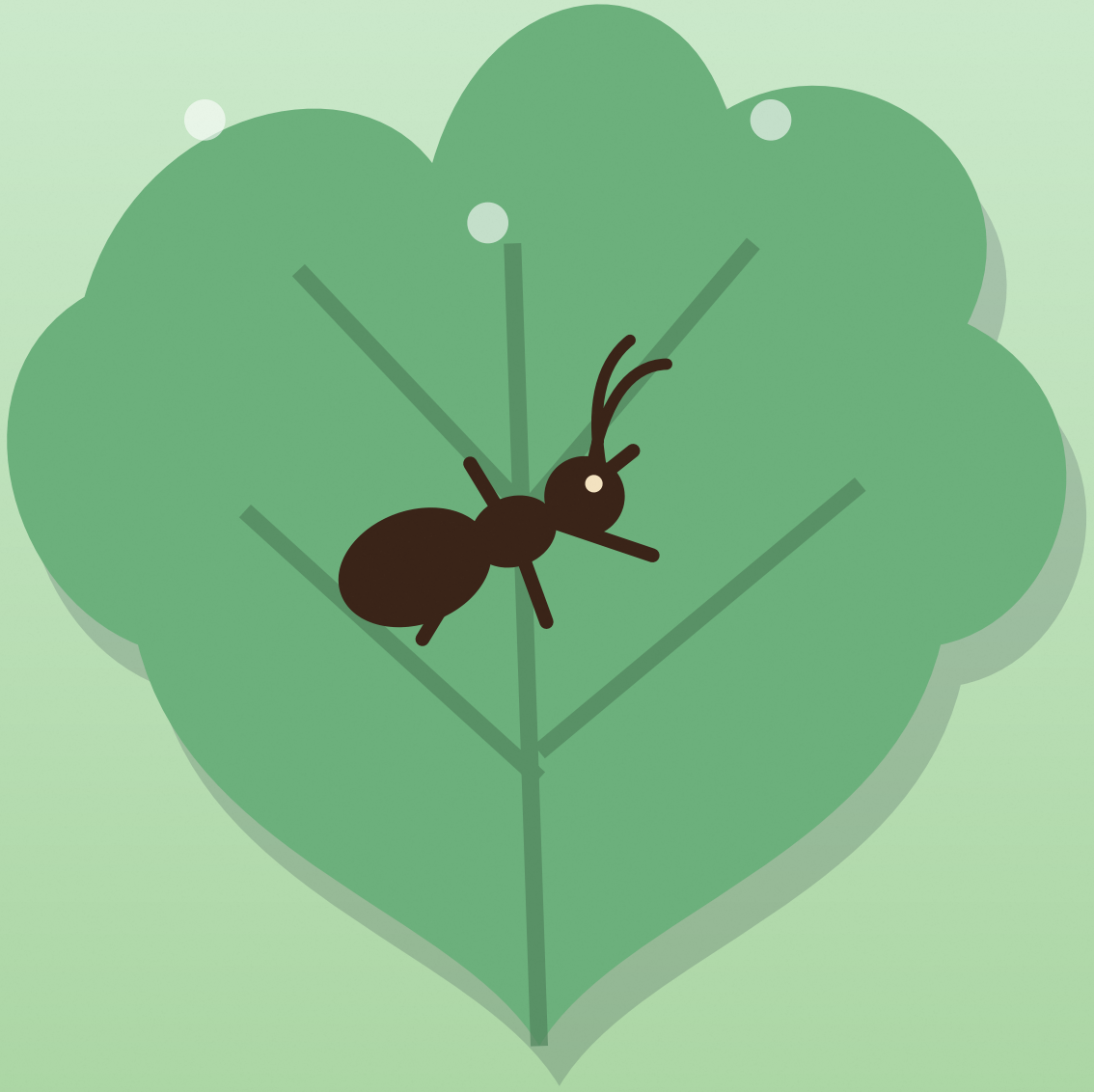


The queen understood. “My Lord,” she said, “I have wronged myself. Now I submit, with Sulayman, to Allah, the Lord of all the worlds.”



Sulayman was a great king with a great army. Yet he listened to a tiny ant, and he thanked Allah for everything.

To Allah, even the smallest creature matters.




And in the quiet valley, the ants are still busy, carrying their seeds home under the stars.

Say Sulayman's prayer

Sulayman said it when he heard the ant. You can say it to thank Allah for something good.

رَبِّ أَوْزِعْنِيٓ أَنْ أَشْكُرَ نِعْمَتَكَ

Rabbi awzi'nī an ashkura ni'matak

My Lord, help me to be grateful for Your blessing

ٱلَّتِيٓ أَنْعَمْتَ عَلَيَّ

allatī an'amta 'alayya

that You have given me.

From Surah An-Naml, 27:19

What does the story teach us?



Say thank you to Allah.
Sulayman had so much, and he was grateful for all of it.



Be kind to small creatures.
Sulayman stopped a whole army for some ants.



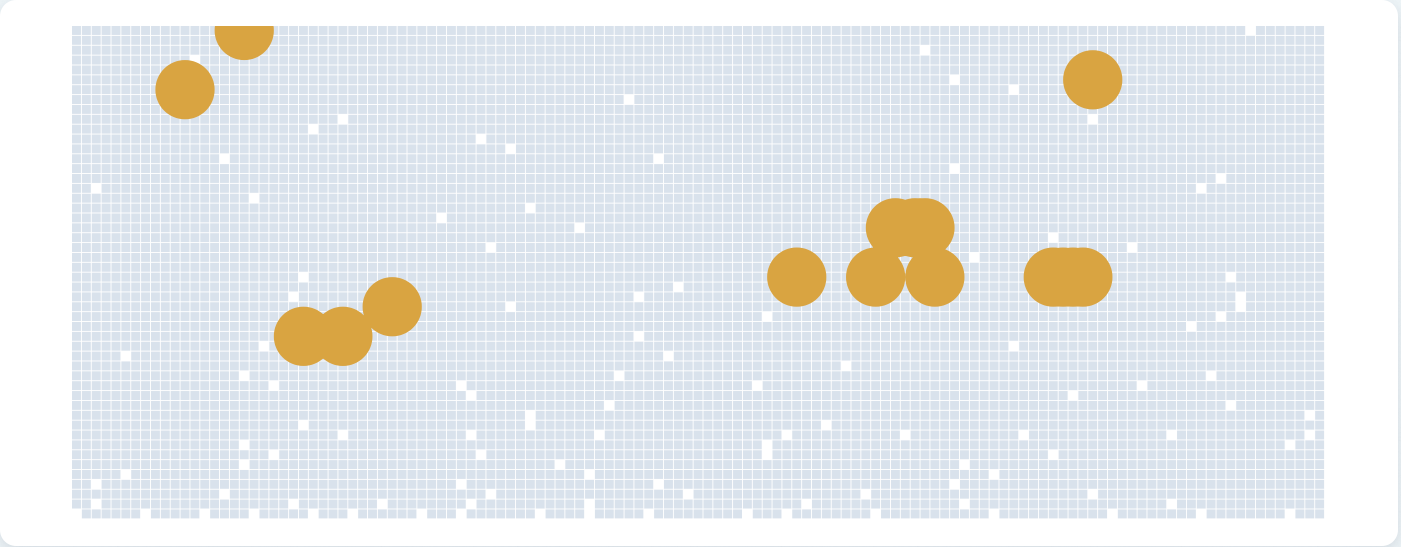
Check what you hear.
“We shall see if you are telling the truth,” said Sulayman to the hoopoe.



Everything good is from Allah.
“This is from the kindness of my Lord.”

Did you know?

Sulayman's name appears **17** times in the Quran.



Every verse of the Quran is one tiny square, starting at the top right like a page of the Quran. Each dot is a verse that names Sulayman.

The word for ant, *naml*, is in just one verse of the whole Quran (27:18), the verse where the ant speaks. And the surah is named after her: **Surah An-Naml, The Ant**, number 27. The hoopoe is named only once too (27:20).

Look closer

Some pictures hide a secret from the Quran itself. Go back and find them.

p. 2–18	A tiny ant hides on every story page. Can you find them all?
p. 8	The empty place in the line of birds. “Why do I not see the hoopoe?” (27:20).
p. 11	The letter’s seal. “In the name of Allah, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful” begins every surah but one. Here it appears in the middle of a surah, the only time (27:30). Count them all, and there are 114: one for each surah.
p. 14	The sparkles: the throne arrived “before your eye blinks” (27:40).
p. 15	Fish under the floor. The palace floor was “smooth glass” over water (27:44).

For parents

Where the story is told. An-Naml 27:15–44, with Saba' 34:12–15 and Al-Anbiya 21:78–82 for the wind, the jinn and Saba'.

Told in simple words. This is a retelling for young children, not a translation. The queen is not named in the Quran; tradition calls her Bilqis. The one who brought the throne is described only as "one who had knowledge from the Book" (27:40). The hidden ants are the editor's game, not part of the verses.

The pictures. By custom, no prophet is drawn, and in this series no person at all. The pictures show the places, the light and the creatures, so your child can picture the story around them.

Talk about it. Sulayman listened to the smallest creature. Who is someone small or quiet that we should listen to more?

Illustrators welcome. These first pictures are a starting point. Artists are invited to redraw any book; the Books page of the Quran Atlas has a brief for every page.

Arabic text: Tanzil Project (tanzil.net), CC BY 3.0, quoted verbatim. Verse counts: Quranic Arabic Corpus (GPL). Typefaces: Andika, Fraunces, Reem Kufi, Amiri Quran (SIL Open Font License).

Copyright 2026 Quran Atlas, thequranatlas.com. Words and pictures licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0), creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-sa/4.0. You may copy, print, share and translate this book for free, with credit to Quran Atlas. You may not sell it or use it commercially, and anything made from it must be shared under the same licence.